

WELLNESS ISN'T A LUXURY

it's a priority

*Barbershop Initiative: A Grant for MEN'S Mental Health Advocacy
at the University Of Massachusetts Amherst*



*By Eben Ampofo
On behalf of The Confess Project*

Dec. 13, 2025

Pop-Up Research & Scholarship Grants Review Committee

December 15, 2025

The Steve Fund
3470 Olney-Laytonsville Road, #313
Olney, Maryland 2

Dear Juanita Taylor,

On behalf of *The Confess Project of America*, I respectfully submit this proposal requesting \$2,000 in support of a campus-based pilot to be implemented in partnership with the University of Massachusetts Amherst. This project aligns directly with The Steve Fund's commitment to advancing mental health equity for marginalized students by supporting community-centered, culturally grounded approaches to engagement.

Although the popularity of social media has brought about a nationwide spread of awareness for mental health. Many men are left feeling unheard, particularly Black men remain disconnected from traditional systems of care that do not take into account the unmet needs for male involvement. Community-based advocacy models, especially those led by trusted figures, offer an important opportunity to bridge this gap. The Confess Project of America has demonstrated national leadership in this space through its work training barbers as mental health advocates in communities across the country.

This proposal builds on that existing model by adapting it to a university setting. Through a short-term, on-campus training, The Confess Project will equip student barbers and campus-affiliated barbers with advocacy tools they can integrate into their existing roles as established community members. Rather than creating a new service or duplicating clinical care, the Barbershop Initiative focuses on strengthening early engagement, stigma reduction, and peer-level support within spaces students already trust.

Thank you for considering this proposal. We believe this partnership represents a strong fit for *The Steve Fund's Pop-Up Research & Scholarship Grants* and appreciate the opportunity to contribute to ongoing efforts to expand culturally responsive mental health engagement among students.

Sincerely,

Ebenezer Ampofo

On behalf of **The Confess Project of America**
University of Massachusetts Amherst
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Statement of Problem

Mental health systems continue to fail men, resulting in disproportionately poor mental health outcomes. Despite rising public attention to mental health over the past decade, both globally and within the United States, men account for the majority of deaths by suicide, representing nearly 80% of suicide fatalities. Even as institutions have expanded mental health awareness campaigns, treatment options, and public dialogue around emotional wellbeing, suicide rates among men have remained high. Many of these efforts rely on clinical, self initiated models of care that assume individuals will seek help on their own.

Cultural expectations surrounding masculinity, however, discourage emotional disclosure and frame help seeking as a sign of weakness rather than a healthy practice. As a result, many men internalize stress, depression, and anxiety and, rather than seeking support, release these emotions in unhealthy ways. Men often feel limited in the spaces and relationships where they can safely express themselves, a reality reinforced by societal norms that dictate how men are expected to live. This constraint negatively affects their perception of self: the stoic, nonchalant man is praised, while the emotionally expressive man is dismissed or ridiculed, regardless of whether that expression is positive or negative.

In most cases, men internalize these messages, and the few “acceptable” outlets for emotional expression become a romantic partner, physical exertion, or emotional outbursts. From an early age, men are taught that emotional restraint, self reliance, and endurance will protect them from being perceived as toxic or undesirable. This internal conflict creates a disconnect that highlights a critical gap between the availability of mental health resources and men’s willingness or ability to engage with them.

In addition to these societal pressures, structural inequality and cultural stigma further intensify these challenges for marginalized populations. For Black men, additional barriers to mental health support include systemic mistrust of healthcare institutions, familial neglect of mental health, and entrenched social stigma, all of which restrict engagement with and desire for mental health services. Black men are often expected to endure emotional hardship privately and are told that vulnerability signifies weakness, leading to avoidance of care and a heightened pressure to perform strength, even reflected in cultural spaces such as music and media. Together, these factors present a clear need for mental health systems that address Black male mental health through approaches that differ from traditional models. Effective solutions must engage individuals within trusted, everyday environments where openness, connection, and authenticity already exist.

Statement of Request

This proposal requests \$2,000 in funding from The Steve Fund to support a small-scale, campus-based mental health advocacy training at the University of Massachusetts Amherst. The requested funds will support the planning and delivery of a short-term pilot training in which Confess Project facilitators travel to UMass Amherst to train barbers, students, and campus affiliates in foundational mental health advocacy skills. Funding will support training facilitation and travel, space reservation, educational materials, and participant engagement costs necessary for program delivery. The training will equip student barbers with foundational mental health literacy, active listening skills, stigma reduction strategies, and guidance on connecting peers to appropriate campus and community resources. Student barbers will not function as clinicians, but rather as trained advocates who foster supportive conversations within trusted, informal campus

spaces. The program will operate as a one time visit with two sessions during the academic semester, enabling focus on relevance and reception within the UMass Amherst community. Findings will then be used to inform recommendations for potential future partnerships to support Black male mental health on campus.

Description of Proposed Work

This Initiative hopes to bring certified barbers under the 2-year “Train-the-Trainer Certification” from their home bases located in Atlanta, GA, to UMass Amherst. They would arrive on a two day stay to deliver structured mental health advocacy programming and leave capacity behind by equipping local barbers with skills they can integrate into their existing roles. Rather than operating as an ongoing service or replacement to clinical care, the pilot focuses on engagement and learning within a university context. The proposed project is organized into three phases:

- (1) on-campus education and training
- (2) post-training application within existing barber and client relationships
- (3) reflection and evaluation.

3.1 Program Overview & Scope

The Barbershop Initiative hopes to bring a shift to how barbers are perceived in the UMass community. Student barbers and campus-affiliated barbers are positioned as trusted members who already engage in recurring, informal conversations with peers. Through targeted advocacy training, participating barbers will gain:

- Active listening and positive communication techniques
- Emotional intelligence cues for mental health crisis navigation
- Validation skills and stigma reduction strategies
- Recognition of mental health warning signs
- Culturally responsive support methods

These tools are foundational in recognizing emotional distress, engaging in supportive dialogue, and encouraging appropriate help seeking when necessary. This training does not hope to provide therapy, diagnosis, or clinical intervention, nor does it offer full Confess Project certification. Instead, it functions as a campus adapted introduction to advocacy-informed practices that complement existing mental health resources available to UMass students of color by strengthening opportunities for engagement in environments they already know and trust. By situating mental health conversations in familiar settings, the aim is to reduce stigma around help-seeking and encourage healthier habits of emotional expression within spaces where students already feel comfortable.

3.2 Program Development & Preparation

During the preparation phase, representatives from The Confess Project will collaborate with campus partners to coordinate logistics and identify participants. Outreach efforts will prioritize student barbers and campus-affiliated barbers who are already embedded within campus grooming spaces or informal peer support networks. Additional outreach will occur through Black cultural organizations and campus partners to promote awareness of the initiative and the associated educational programming.

Training materials will be adapted from The Confess Project's existing mental health advocacy framework to reflect the campus context. This adaptation will account for common stressors experienced by college students and Black male students in particular, while maintaining the cultural grounding that defines The Confess Project's approach. Preparation activities will also include reserving an appropriate campus space, confirming the training schedule, and coordinating travel and facilitation arrangements for Confess Project representatives.

3.3 Training Structure & Content

Training will be delivered over two consecutive days, each serving a distinct purpose within the overall program structure. The first day will consist of an informational, campus wide educational session open to students, staff, and faculty. This session will introduce The Confess Project's mission, explain the role of barbers as mental health advocates, and provide context on men's mental health and community based interventions. The session may include contributions from campus-affiliated mental health professionals or researchers to contextualize existing studies, such as research on barbers as mental health gatekeepers, alongside lived experience perspectives from Confess Project barbers.

The second day will focus on applied advocacy training and will be limited to student barbers and campus-affiliated barbers. This facilitated workshop will emphasize discussion based learning and practical application rather than lecture style instruction. Core topics will include mental health literacy, de-escalation techniques, active listening skills, stigma reduction strategies, and ethical referral practices. Participants will engage with scenario based exercises that reflect real conversations encountered during barber client interactions, allowing them to practice responding supportively while understanding the boundaries of their role.

Throughout the training, facilitators will reinforce that barbers are not responsible for diagnosis or treatment, but instead serve as advocates who normalize conversations about mental health, foster trust, and guide peers toward appropriate campus or community resources when needed.

3.4 Post Training Application & Evaluation

Following the training, participating barbers will return to their existing roles and integrate advocacy informed communication practices into their normal appointments. No new services will be created, and no additional cost will be associated with these appointments. Clients may optionally choose to book with a barber who has completed the training, signaling openness to conversation during the service rather than requesting clinical support.

To support learning and evaluation, clients who opt into appointments with trained barbers may be invited to complete brief, voluntary pre and post appointment surveys. These surveys are not designed to assess mental health status or outcomes, but rather to capture perceptions of comfort, support, and engagement during the interaction. Pre appointment prompts may assess openness to informal conversation, while post appointment prompts may invite reflection on whether the interaction felt respectful, supportive, and worth engaging in again.

In addition to client feedback, participating barbers will be invited to reflect on their comfort applying the training, perceived usefulness of the advocacy tools, and challenges encountered. Feedback from both barbers and clients will be synthesized to assess feasibility, identify strengths and limitations of the model, and inform recommendations for future programming or partnerships.

Description of Proposed Facilities

The pilot will be conducted at the University of Massachusetts Amherst, utilizing existing campus facilities to support training and coordination activities. UMass Amherst offers accessible, reservable meeting and workshop spaces suitable for small group instruction, discussion based learning, and facilitated training sessions. These spaces provide the necessary seating, audiovisual equipment, and accessibility accommodations required for effective program delivery. The training will take place in a campus-affiliated space located near student activity and residential areas, allowing for convenient participation by student barbers and campus-affiliated barbers. No specialized clinical facilities are required, as the program is designed to operate within informal, community based environments rather than traditional medical or counseling settings. In addition to physical space, the project will leverage existing campus infrastructure for communication and coordination, including university email systems and online platforms for participant outreach and post training feedback collection. These facilities and resources ensure that the proposed pilot can be implemented efficiently without the need for new or permanent infrastructure investments.

4.1 Measures of Project Success

The success of this initiative will be evaluated through participation, engagement, and feedback based indicators rather than clinical mental health outcomes. Because the program is designed as a short term, exploratory pilot, measures of success focus on feasibility, relevance, and perceived value among both participating barbers and clients.

One indicator of success will be participant engagement during the training phase. This includes the number of student barbers and campus-affiliated barbers who complete the applied advocacy

training, as well as their active participation in discussion activities and scenario exercises. High levels of attendance and completion will indicate that the training structure and content are accessible and appropriate for a campus setting.

A second measure of success will be barber self-reported confidence and perceived usefulness of the training. Participating barbers will be invited to reflect on their comfort applying advocacy communication practices, their understanding of role boundaries, and the relevance of the tools provided. These reflections will help assess whether the training effectively equips barbers to integrate advocacy practices into their existing interactions without requiring additional services or infrastructure.

Client engagement will serve as an additional measure of success. Clients who opt into appointments with trained barbers may voluntarily complete brief prior and post appointment surveys focused on comfort, perceived attentiveness, and overall experience. These surveys are not intended to assess mental health status, but rather to evaluate whether advocacy informed interactions are perceived as supportive and whether clients would choose to engage with a trained barber again in the future.

Finally, the overall program feasibility will be assessed through logistical outcomes, including the ability to coordinate training delivery, adapt materials to a campus context, and implement the pilot within a single academic semester. Collectively, these measures will provide meaningful insight into the strengths, limitations, and scalability of a Confess Project advocacy model within a university environment and will inform recommendations for potential future programming or partnerships.

4.2 Available Facilities

The sessions will be hosted at the University of Massachusetts Amherst, in campus spaces that support educational programming, community dialogue, and small to mid sized gatherings.

Based on prior experience coordinating campus wide events through registered student organizations, the project will rely on reservable university spaces and established event approval processes to ensure smooth implementation.

The primary location for the on campus programming will be the New Africa House Basement Theater, a space affiliated with the Department of Black Studies. This venue is well suited for the goals of the project, as it provides a culturally grounded environment that supports social engagement, discussion, and community building. The theater includes fixed seating, a projection screen, and audiovisual capabilities appropriate for presentations, panel discussions, and facilitated dialogue.

The space can comfortably accommodate the expected 50–100 attendees for the Day 1 informational session, while also supporting smaller, focused group activities during the Day 2 applied advocacy training. Using New Africa House aligns the program with existing academic and cultural resources on campus and reinforces the project's focus on Black student wellbeing and community based learning.

The Day 2 applied training will take place in the same campus space to maintain continuity and accessibility for participants. Because the focus of the initiative is education and advocacy training rather than haircutting services, no specialized barber equipment is required for program delivery. Any demonstration materials or tools used during training will be provided by The Confess Project as part of their facilitation. Lighting needs, if required, for instructional or

documentation purposes, will be minimal and addressed through existing campus resources or modest rental arrangements outlined in the project budget.

Bringing external facilitators or speakers to campus follows established university procedures. Guest speakers and trainers are engaged through standard service agreements that outline the scope of work, scheduling expectations, and cancellation policies. These agreements are coordinated through campus event approval systems and reviewed by university officials as needed, ensuring transparency and compliance with institutional guidelines.

Travel and lodging for Confess Project facilitators will be coordinated in advance. When overnight accommodations are required, lodging may be provided through Hotel UMass, which is commonly used for visiting speakers and collaborators. A typical stay consists of one to two nights, with an estimated cost of approximately \$320 total, covering check in the evening prior to the event and check out following program completion. Exact dates and arrangements will be finalized during the preparation phase of the project.

All proposed facilities and logistical support already exist within the university infrastructure, and no permanent installations or long term space commitments are required. Prior experience coordinating comparable campus events demonstrates that the proposed activities are possible within the project's timeline and budget. By utilizing established spaces, standard contracting procedures, and existing campus resources, the initiative minimizes logistical barriers while maintaining a professional and organized implementation structure.

To support the evaluation component, the project will engage student volunteers or student researchers, particularly Black and Brown students pursuing fields such as psychology, public health, or social sciences. Participation in this role will be framed as a professional development opportunity rather than a compensated research position, allowing students to gain experience in program evaluation and community based initiatives while keeping project costs manageable. The project will leverage existing campus infrastructure for communication, coordination, and evaluation. Outreach and scheduling will utilize university email systems and campus partner networks. Voluntary surveys and reflections will be administered using online platforms commonly employed for academic and program evaluation purposes.

Qualification of Personnel

This section addresses responsibility and qualification for the proposed pilot. The initiative will be implemented through a structured collaboration among The Confess Project of America, campus-affiliated mental health and academic contributors, and student and community participants. Each group contributes distinct, complementary expertise that supports effective delivery, ethical integrity, and academic credibility.

5.1 The Confess Project of America

The Confess Project of America is a national nonprofit organization with a well established record of training barbers to serve as mental health advocates within their communities. To date, the organization has trained more than 4,000 barbers across 31 states and 54 cities, demonstrating both scale and sustainability. Its work is grounded in a culturally responsive,

community based model that centers the lived experiences of Black men and other populations that have historically encountered structural barriers to traditional mental health care.

The organization's approach has been further validated through research collaboration with Harvard University, including peer reviewed scholarship examining barbers as trusted community gatekeepers and the effectiveness of informal settings in promoting early mental health engagement. This research base underscores the credibility of the Confess Project's model and its relevance to preventive, stigma reduction strategies.

Within this pilot, representatives from The Confess Project will serve as the primary training facilitators. Their role will focus on delivering advocacy centered instruction, leading scenario based and discussion driven learning activities, and reinforcing ethical distinctions between peer advocacy and clinical intervention. Drawing on extensive experience implementing similar training in diverse community contexts, the organization is well positioned to adapt its framework to a campus environment while maintaining fidelity to its established, evidence informed model.

5.2 Campus Mental Health and Academic Contributors

Campus-affiliated mental health professionals and academic contributors will support the pilot in an informational and contextual capacity. This group may include university based therapists, psychiatrists, or faculty researchers with expertise in men's mental health, community based interventions, health disparities, or student wellbeing. Their involvement is intentionally non-clinical and educational, ensuring that the project remains within appropriate ethical and professional boundaries.

These contributors may participate in the Day 1 informational session by presenting relevant research findings, such as evidence on community based mental health advocacy, preventive approaches, and disparities in mental health outcomes among Black men. By situating the Confess Project's training model within established academic literature and campus health frameworks, their participation enhances institutional grounding and intellectual rigor.

Clear role delineation ensures that campus contributors do not provide diagnosis or treatment, but instead strengthen the pilot's credibility by linking advocacy training to research, theory, and existing campus resources.

5.3 Student and Community Participants

Student barbers and campus-affiliated barbers will constitute the primary trainee group for the applied advocacy component of the project. Many of these participants already occupy trusted roles within campus grooming spaces or informal peer networks, positioning them to integrate advocacy informed communication practices into interactions that naturally occur in their daily routines. Their participation is voluntary and focused on skill building and awareness, rather than the provision of mental health services.

Additional students may attend the Day 1 informational session as general participants, including members of Black cultural organizations, student barber networks, and other campus groups with an interest in men's mental health and community based support. These attendees will engage at an educational level only, supporting broader dialogue and awareness without expanding training responsibilities or expectations.

To support the evaluation component, student volunteers, particularly Black and Brown students pursuing psychology, public health, or social science disciplines, may assist with organizing and synthesizing participant feedback. This role will be structured strictly for a professional development opportunity, offering experiential learning in program evaluation and community engaged research while contributing to the overall assessment and continuous improvement goals.

Budget

This proposal requests \$2,000 to support a short term, campus based initiative implemented in partnership with The Confess Project of America. The budget prioritizes direct costs required to deliver the two day training and support limited evaluation activities.

Budget Summary Table

Category	Description	Amount
Training Facilitation	Payment for Confess Project Facilitators Day 1 & Day 2 training	\$900
Travel & Lodging	Lodging at Hotel UMass (\$325 - 1 night) & transportation	\$600
Program Materials & Supplies	Printed handouts, training materials, scenario-based activity	\$250
Participant Engagement	Light refreshments & engagement supplies	\$150
Evaluation & Documentation	Feedback collection materials(non-clinical)	\$100

Total Request		\$2000
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6.1 Training Facilitation and Travel

Budgeted funds will cover payment for Confess Project facilitators responsible for delivering the Day 1 session and Day 2 applied advocacy training. This line item reflects the direct cost of program delivery by qualified personnel.

6.2 Program Materials and Supplies

Funds will also be allocated toward program materials and supplies required for the training and educational sessions. These may include printed educational materials, workshop handouts, and resources used during discussion-based and scenario based activities. All materials will be instructional in nature and aligned with The Confess Project's advocacy framework.

6.3 Space and Event Logistics

The program will rely on existing campus venues to keep costs low. Any modest logistical expenses associated with hosting the sessions, including space reservation and basic A/V support, will be covered as needed. Day 1 is planned for the New Africa House Basement Theater, which is an appropriate venue for the expected audience size and allows the project to use built-in presentation capabilities without additional equipment costs. Day 2 will be hosted in the same space or a nearby reservable room to reduce setup complexity and avoid added logistical expenses. No specialized barber equipment will be purchased; the initiative is training centered, and any demonstration tools, if used, will be supplied by participants or Confess Project facilitators.

6.4 Program Materials and Supplies

Funds will also be used for training materials required for instruction and participant learning, including printed handouts, workshop prompts, and other low cost instructional supplies used in scenario based activities. Materials will remain limited to items that directly support training delivery.

6.5 Participation Engagement and Evaluation Support

A small portion of the budget will support participant engagement needs (ex: light refreshments during longer sessions) to maintain attendance and participation. Minimal funds will also support non clinical evaluation logistics, such as printing brief feedback materials or other basic documentation needs. Promotional outreach will primarily use no cost campus channels (email distribution and digital signage), reducing marketing expenses.

Summary

Men in America, especially Black men, continue to experience disproportionately poor mental health outcomes while remaining underserved by traditional, self initiated clinical models of care. Cultural stigma, structural barriers, and limited culturally grounded points of entry often prevent early engagement with mental health resources. This proposal responds to that gap by advancing a community based, advocacy oriented approach that meets individuals in trusted, everyday spaces rather than requiring them to adapt to systems that do not effectively reach them.

On behalf of The Confess Project of America, this proposal requests \$2,000 from The Steve Fund to support a short term, campus based Barbershop Initiative at the University of

Massachusetts Amherst. The project adapts The Confess Project's established framework to a university setting through a two day program that combines campus wide education with applied training for student and campus affiliated barbers. By equipping trusted community members with advocacy skills, the pilot strengthens early engagement, stigma reduction, and peer level support without replacing existing clinical services.

Designed as a focused pilot, the project emphasizes feasibility, relevance, and learning.

Evaluation efforts will assess participant engagement and perceived value, generating insight that can inform future partnerships and campus based mental health initiatives. This proposal reflects The Steve Fund's commitment to supporting innovative, culturally responsive approaches to student well being and offers a practical, scalable model for expanding mental health engagement among marginalized students.

Composition Narrative

I pieced together this paper through a staged writing process that began with the feasibility study and translated into a formal grant proposal. The initial feasibility study allowed me to explore the scope of the project, evaluate potential nonprofit partners, and assess whether the work could be realistically completed within the semester. During which I realized the scope of the project was too large for what was feasible, so I examined multiple directions for the project and ultimately decided to focus on Black male mental health and community based advocacy models. Still the goal of what would be implemented was still too grand and needed to scale down. I was aware a common theme across my ideas was the Confess Project at the center. A meeting with my professor opened my eyes to writing the grant on behalf of the Confess Project instead of reinventing the wheel of an already tested working program.

When transitioning from feasibility to the grant proposal, I made intentional rhetorical shifts to align with the expectations of grant writing. I reframed the project from the perspective of a nonprofit applicant seeking funding and narrowed the scope from a broad, ongoing program to a short-term pilot that emphasized a feasible timeline, clarity, and alignment with The Steve Fund's Pop-Up Research & Scholarship Grants. Decisions about structure were guided by sample proposals provided for the assignment. Revision focused primarily on clarity, coherence, and genre consistency. I revised the Statement of the Problem to move from general claims to explained conditions, ensuring that each paragraph demonstrated cause and effect rather than simply stating conclusions. Other sections, such as the Statement of Request and Description of Proposed Work, were refined to reduce excessive detailed explanation and a less personal tone appropriate for a funding audience. Bulleted formatting was used selectively in sections like the budget and training content to improve readability and scannability. Editing was the final stage of the process and focused on sentence level refinement, transitions, and grammatical accuracy.

ChatGPT Use

I used ChatGPT as a writing and planning support tool during the development of this paper. Specifically, it assisted with clarifying concepts, cleaning up grammatical errors, refining sentence structure, and helping translate ideas into the grant proposal format recommended by my instructor. ChatGPT was also used to help generate supporting writing outlines, visualize the scope of the proposed project, and ensure alignment between sections. All final writing decisions, revisions, and content selection were made by me, and the tool was used as a supplemental aid rather than a replacement for original thinking or research.

Appendix

The Steve Fund is thrilled to partner with the [National Center for Institutional Diversity](#) on the next round of Pop-up Research & Scholarship grants! Pop-Up Grants provide an opportunity for scholars to actively engage in [diversity research and scholarship](#) around emerging or re-emerging social issues and quickly disseminate findings to the public.

Announcement from NCID:

Diversity scholars (with priority given to members of the [Diversity Scholars Network](#)) are eligible for this opportunity. Scholars may apply for up to \$2,000 in funding for a 6-month grant period. Grant recipients will receive support in planning and executing a dissemination strategy.

Grant recipients will submit a draft for NCID's [Currents](#) publication (hosted by Michigan Publishing). Currents seeks to connect diversity scholarship to practice in education and society.

We welcome proposals that focus on the topic of mental health among marginalized communities.

There has been an increase in prevalence of mental health issues among students, which can be a detriment to the students' academic performance and general well-being. Academic leaders have identified mental health as their number one concern and are searching for evidence and guidance to better support students. Mental health issues can particularly affect those from marginalized populations, such as people of color, low-income people, LGBTQ individuals, disabled people/people with disabilities, and immigrants. We are looking for scholars to further our understandings around the experiences of marginalized populations and their mental health. Understandings of this concept may be approached in various ways. For example:

- Barriers and strengths (e.g., related to structural, social, cultural, and identity processes)
- Relational contexts (e.g., families, peers, natural mentors, networks, especially those not usually included as relevant to well-being)
- Space and place (e.g., attention to climate in broader campus and day-to-day academic and social contexts, attention to region, digital media, virtual spaces)
- Innovative interventions that may tie some of the above together
- Historical approaches to understanding mental health among marginalized individuals
- Cultural production that promotes and addresses mental health
- Creative approaches to understanding mental health

Given the timeframe and goals of this opportunity, proposed projects must have IRB approval. We strongly recommend that scholars use existing data.

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